

THE SAN MIGUEL EDITION

# Buyer's Guide

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Financing · Fidelmiso Trusts · Closing Costs  
Neighborhood Pricing · Buying as a Foreigner

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# Contents

01 Why Americans Are Moving Here

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02 Best Neighborhoods

---

03 Cost of Living

---

04 The Buying Process

---

05 Financing Options

---

06 Fideicomiso Trusts, Explained

---

07 Closing Costs & Property Taxes

---

08 Mistakes to Avoid

---

09 Frequently Asked Questions

---

10 Next Steps

---

## Why Americans Are Moving Here

San Miguel de Allende has spent the last two decades quietly becoming one of the most sought-after relocation destinations in North America — and the reasons go well beyond the exchange rate.

A UNESCO World Heritage historic center, a genuine year-round arts community, walkable cobblestone streets, and a climate that rarely sees a hard winter or a punishing summer all play a part. So does a slower, more social pace of daily life that many buyers say they didn't know they were missing.

- A well-established, English-speaking expat community alongside deep Mexican tradition
- Direct flights from several major U.S. hubs into nearby León (BJX)
- A genuinely walkable historic core — rare in a country built around cars
- A lower cost of living without sacrificing quality of healthcare, dining, or culture

*“It's not a retirement community. It's a full, active life that happens to cost less and look better.”*

# Best Neighborhoods

San Miguel isn't one neighborhood — it's six distinct ways of living. A quick overview before the deeper dive later in this guide.



**Centro**  
HISTORIC HEART



**San Antonio**  
ARTISTIC & BOHEMIAN



**Guadiana**  
RESIDENTIAL & QUIET



**Atascadero**  
PANORAMIC VIEWS



**Balcones**  
UPSCALE & GATED



**Los Frailes**  
GROWING VALUE

# Cost of Living

Day-to-day costs in San Miguel run meaningfully lower than most U.S. or Canadian cities, though imported goods and international schooling can narrow that gap for some households.

ILLUSTRATIVE ONLY

The figures below are general planning ranges for a comfortable single-person or couple household, not a guarantee — actual costs vary by lifestyle.

|                           |                                                              |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Groceries (local markets) | Noticeably lower than U.S. average                           |
| Dining out                | \$5–15 for a casual meal, \$30–60+ for a nice dinner for two |
| Household help            | Widely available and affordable                              |
| Utilities                 | Lower electricity use overall thanks to the climate          |
| Healthcare                | Private care often a fraction of U.S. list prices            |

The single biggest cost lever for most buyers is housing itself — which is exactly why getting neighborhood and pricing right matters more here than almost anywhere else.

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## Ready to See What's Available?

Browse current listings across every San Miguel neighborhood, or tell me what you're looking for and I'll do the searching.

[View Current Listings](#)

## The Buying Process

Buying property in Mexico as a foreign national follows a clear, well-established sequence — it simply looks a little different from what U.S. or Canadian buyers are used to.

- **Offer & acceptance** — a written offer, typically with a small good-faith deposit
- **Promissory agreement** — a preliminary contract outlining terms, timeline, and deposit (usually 10%)
- **Due diligence** — title search, liens check, and property survey handled by your notario
- **Trust or corporation setup** — if using a fideicomiso, the bank trust is established during this window
- **Closing** — final signing before the notario público, funds transfer, and title recording

### GOOD TO KNOW

Most transactions close within 45–75 days of an accepted offer, depending on financing and how quickly the trust paperwork moves.

## Financing Options

Most international buyers in San Miguel purchase in cash or use home-equity financing from their country of residence — this remains the simplest and fastest path to closing.

Mexican mortgages for foreign nationals do exist through a small number of cross-border lenders, typically with higher rates and larger down payments than buyers may expect from home. They can make sense for larger purchases where preserving cash matters more than minimizing borrowing cost.

### WORTH ASKING EARLY

If financing will play any role in your purchase, start that conversation before you fall in love with a property — approval timelines can shape which listings are realistic.

## Fideicomiso Trusts, Explained

A fideicomiso is a bank trust that lets a foreign buyer hold full beneficial rights to a property — the right to live in it, rent it, renovate it, sell it, or pass it to heirs — while a Mexican bank holds legal title as trustee.

San Miguel sits outside Mexico's constitutionally restricted coastal and border zones, so direct ownership is often possible here. Even so, many buyers still choose a fideicomiso or a Mexican corporation for estate-planning reasons or simple consistency with how they hold property elsewhere.

*“The paperwork feels foreign the first time. The rights you end up with are not.”*

- Trusts are typically established in 50-year terms and can be renewed indefinitely
- You can name beneficiaries directly in the trust, which can simplify inheritance
- The trustee bank's role is administrative — it does not manage or make decisions about the property

# Closing Costs & Property Taxes

Buyers should generally budget 5–7% of the purchase price for total closing costs — this covers notary fees, acquisition tax, trust setup (if applicable), and registration.

|                        |                                            |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Acquisition tax        | Typically ~2% of assessed value            |
| Notary & legal fees    | Varies by transaction complexity           |
| Fideicomiso setup      | One-time fee, if using a bank trust        |
| Annual trust fee       | Modest, paid yearly to the trustee bank    |
| Predial (property tax) | Notably low compared to the U.S. or Canada |

GOOD TO KNOW

Property tax in Mexico is famously affordable — many owners are pleasantly surprised the first time their predial bill arrives.

## Mistakes to Avoid

- **Skipping a real due-diligence process** because a property “feels” right
- **Underestimating renovation costs** on older, historic-zone homes with adobe or masonry walls
- **Assuming U.S.-style financing timelines** will apply here
- **Choosing a neighborhood based on a single visit** rather than experiencing it at different times of day and year
- **Not budgeting for closing costs** as a separate line item from the purchase price
- **Working without local representation** who can flag issues before they become expensive

## Frequently Asked Questions

### **Do I need to speak Spanish?**

No — though I can connect you with bilingual notarios, contractors, and service providers throughout the process.

### **Can I close remotely?**

Much of the process can happen remotely, though Mexican law requires signing the final closing documents in person before a notario (a power of attorney can sometimes substitute — ask early).

### **How much should I see in person before buying?**

At minimum, plan one dedicated trip focused on neighborhoods and shortlisted properties — video tours are a great first pass, not a substitute for walking the street yourself.

THANK YOU

## Let's Find Your San Miguel

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